Guide to Academic Writing at WQU

This guide is intended to provide a supplemental resource for students on how to write effectively during their studies at WorldQuant University. This document is not meant to be all-inclusive, but does address common topics that will help students improve and develop as writers at the graduate level. Please note that your instructors may have individual preferences, so they may request you do things differently in your writing. This guide is meant to be a starting point for learning the basics of academic writing at the graduate level.

For topics not covered here, refer to the Modern Language Association (MLA) Handbook (9th edition), as it is the basis for these style guidelines.

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Introductions and Conclusions

Introductions and conclusions are particularly useful for the reader because they help the reader situate new material within the context of what they already know.

Introductions:

Introductions should do 3 things:

1. Contextualize the material within the larger goal or purpose of your assignment and within the field or subject at large. What background knowledge is necessary for the reader to understand the topic at hand? What needs to be explained or introduced about the topic?
2. Summarize the information that will be presented and the order in which it will be covered. This will help guide the reader through your assignment and prepare them for what is to come.
3. Explain the significance and importance of the material overall. Why is this topic important within the field, and what are its implications? In other words, why should the reader care about the information that is about to be presented?

Sample Introduction:

Mortgage-backed securities, specifically the securitization of sub-prime mortgage debt, played an integral role in the Global Financial Crisis. First, I will explain what a mortgage-backed security is and how it works. Then, I will examine the role of mortgage-backed securities in the destabilization of the financial system during the Global Financial Crisis. This research can help to better illuminate how regulations may or may not help to avoid future financial crises and demonstrate other actions that can be taken to stabilize the financial system, especially as it pertains to mortgage-backed securities, during times of economic turbulence.

In yellow, there is a brief summary of the assignment's content. In blue, there is a clear outline of what to expect from the assignment and the order in which information will be presented. In purple, there is a clear explanation of the takeaway for this assignment: for the learner to understand the workflow of a finance project and to learn what excites them about the process.

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Conclusions:

Conclusions should mirror introductions. They should summarize the content that was presented, reinforce the significance or key takeaways of that material, and contextualize the material that was just presented by explaining its larger implications and significance. Remember that by this point, the reader has already read the materials, so instead of talking about the material vaguely, you can add a bit more detail and elaboration into your conclusion because the reader will understand what you are referring to.

Organization

This section covers the use of headings, topic sentences, and transitions, which all help to improve the organization, structure, and flow of content.

Using Headings:

To aid in organization, you can use headings and subheadings to organize your assignments. This can help your reader navigate your assignment more effectively, enabling them to skim the structure of the material upfront and to easily locate material for further review when needed.

When using headings, be mindful of sections or paragraphs that are long or short compared to other sections or paragraphs. No heading is necessary for the introduction, but do use a heading for the conclusion. If using a level of heading, there should always be at least 2 instances of that heading. For example:

- Credit Risk
  - Capacity
  - Capital
  - Character
  - Collateral
  - Conditions
- Mortgage-Backed Securities
- Conclusion

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Using Metadiscourse:

In graduate-level writing, it is common to use metadiscourse, also known as signposting, in your essays and assignments. Metadiscourse refers to words and phrases that you can use to guide the reader through your text. Think of these phrases as signs that help guide someone along the journey of reading your paper. When using metadiscourse, you can signal not only the direction but also the purpose of the material to your reader.

When used purposefully, metadiscourse can be an invaluable tool to help your reader understand the structure and progression of your ideas. However, if you use metadiscourse too often, it will lose its value and will not be as useful or helpful to the reader. Metadiscourse is most useful at the beginning and ends of major sections or ideas and at key points of transition within your assignment. Below are examples of different kind of metadiscourse that can be helpful to incorporate into your materials:

Forecasting:

Forecasting language allows you to outline upcoming material for the reader. This is especially helpful at the beginning of your assignment but can also be useful at the start of a major section within your assignment. Depending on whether it's your individual assignment or a group assignment, using either "I" or "we" might be appropriate. This type of forecasting statement at the beginning of your paper will help your reader know what to expect as they read:

> First, we will explain the Spearman correlation. Then, we will compare the Spearman correlation to Kendall's tau. Finally, we will discuss situations where using the Spearman correlation is more effective than using Kendall's tau.

Notice how the sentences above set up a clear outline for the content of an assignment. The reader knows exactly what to expect. You could also incorporate headings for each of these sections that will match up with the organization presented here to reinforce the structure of the material. At the end of your assignment, you can summarize what you've written by using similar language but in the past tense, along with any additional details or context you want to incorporate.

> In this assignment, we first provided an overview of the Spearman correlation and compared it to Kendall's tau. Afterwards, we discussed specific contexts in which it would make the most sense to use the Spearman correlation rather than Kendall's tau. Using the Spearman correlation makes the most sense when…

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Transitions:

Transitional phrases can be helpful for alerting the reader to important changes in thought or topic in your assignment. Perhaps you are giving an important list of characteristics or applying a concept to a real-world context. Words like "nevertheless," "now," "therefore," "however," "first," and "in conclusion" tell your reader what is happening in your assignment by establishing relationships between what you've already discussed and what you're about to discuss. For instance, the example below might help to transition from one paragraph about skewness in statistical analysis to the next paragraph about kurtosis.

> While skewness is important for evaluating a dataset, it's important to consider kurtosis as well to determine the influence of outliers.

Voice and Tone

In your writing, your tone should be academic in nature. This means that you should come across as professional and objective as you write. Avoid using informal language, and look to sample textbooks, journal articles, and other research in your field as an example of how your writing should sound.

As part of academic tone, it is important to be straightforward and concise. As such, it's best to use the active voice. While the passive voice can be helpful, active voice is generally preferred in academic writing. First, we'll explain what passive voice is, and then we'll compare and contrast the two to show why active voice is generally more effective.

Passive voice means that the subject is obscured; it is unclear who or what is performing the action. For example: "The price of goods has been drastically impacted." By what or whom? This sentence construction obscures the subject, the person or thing impacting the price of goods. Even if we attribute the cause at the end of the sentence as such, "The price of goods has been drastically impacted by inflation," the sentence is less direct than it could or should be. "Inflation" is the real subject of the sentence here--it is what's causing the drastic change to the price of goods. However, passive voice positions that subject at the end of the sentence, making the relationship more indirect and placing more emphasis on the object receiving the action--"the price of goods." Passive voice is often used as a way to deflect blame or avoid responsibility, so it is best to write in active voice whenever possible. However, in situations where the

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object receiving the action is more important than the subject, passive voice is permissible.

Active voice means the subject (the who or what of the sentence) is performing the action of the sentence. For example, let's take the sentence we used in the paragraph above and put it into the active voice: Inflation can drastically impact the price of goods. In this sentence, the subject is "inflation" and "can impact" is the action. We've restructured the sentence to place the subject, the one performing the action, at the beginning of the sentence. This allows the reader to more clearly see that it is inflation that is the subject of the sentence and that inflation can impact (action) the price of goods (the object, what is being affected by the subject). It is easier to understand this type of construction because information is presented in the order you would expect: the subject, the action, and the recipient of the action.

Microsoft Word has a passive voice checker that can be useful for detecting instances of passive voice, especially in situations where the actor is completely unknown, which usually means there's no "by" phrase at the end of the sentence to indicate who or what is performing the action. Try to revise instances of passive voice with an unknown actor, and use active voice whenever possible in place of other instances of passive voice.

Grammar and Mechanics

This section outlines preferences and rules related to grammar, mechanics, and style. It is not a comprehensive overview of English grammar but is intended to provide some tips and tricks as you write at the graduate-level. **If you are ever unsure of a grammatical rule, look it up and try to practice it in your writing.**

Punctuation:

- Use a serial comma before "and" in lists of more than two items:

  economics, finance, and mathematics

- Use commas after introductory information, including conjunctive adverbs, dependent clauses, prepositional phrases, and transitional phrases:

  Then, this section will cover…

  Therefore, the importance of this theory…

  In this assignment, you will…

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- When using a colon to introduce information or elaborate upon an idea, the colon must be preceded by an independent clause:

  This forum post covers two important concepts: securitization and collateralization.

  NOT This forum post covers: securitization and collateralization.

- Only use a semicolon to separate two independent clauses or to separate bulky or wordy items in a list:

  Without data, there is no project; it is as simple as that.

  Some examples of the statistical techniques used to build these models include linear regression; random forests; gradient boosting; support vector machines; neural networks; clustering; self-organizing maps; and many more.

- Periods and commas always go inside quotation marks. Question marks and semicolons can be placed outside under certain circumstances (semicolons generally are). Look up usage for specific punctuation if unsure.
  - The exception to this rule is with in-text citations. If your sentence ends with an in-text citation, it should be formatted as follows, with the end quotation mark, followed by the parenthetical, and then the period: …" (Hughes 54).

- Limit use of quotation marks to direct quotations. Avoid using them to emphasize words or phrases.

- Do not use exclamation points or ellipses—these are generally not needed in academic writing.

Capitalization:

- Follow standard rules for capitalization:
  - Capitalize the first word of a sentence:

    This module will cover…

  - Capitalize names and proper nouns, meaning the specific name for a particular thing, like a brand name, company, etc.

    New York Stock Exchange

    Euclidean distance

    CryptoKitty genome mapping

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- When referencing specific works or sources in text, use title case, meaning capitalize the first word, all principal words, and the last word.

  Practical Methods of Financial Engineering and Risk Management

  An Introduction to Quantitative Finance

- Utilize content-specific capitalization as provided in standard and credible industry-specific websites or publications.
- Use title case, not sentence case, for headings: “The Securitization Transformation” not “The securitization transformation”

Spelling:

- Use the American spelling of words:

  “labor” instead of “labour”

  “summarize” instead of “summarise”

- Add unrecognized words to your dictionary in Microsoft Word or Google Docs to avoid typos.

Other Rules:

- Terms to be abbreviated or referred to with acronyms should be written out the first time they are used, followed by the abbreviation or acronym in parentheses—e.g., mortgage-backed securities (MBS).
- Use **one space, not two spaces**, at the end of a sentence before the next sentence:

  In this paper, I discuss credit risk and how to analyze it conceptually. I will also discuss some of the other risks inherent to a mortgage.

Writing Resources

Below, we’ve gathered some helpful writing resources. Be sure to check out the anti-plagiarism guide as well for information on how to avoid plagiarism through proper citation and attribution.

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WQU's Anti-Plagiarism Guide: https://docs.google.com/document/d/1s954jXLg4I7Nc2EQyXkMmlgg1cfxO2_5w5W_o9eU1qs/edit?usp=sharing

How to Cite Source Code in MLA: https://style.mla.org/citing-source-code/

Merriam-Webster: http://www.merriam-webster.com/ – for reference on spellings

Merriam-Webster's Learner's Dictionary: https://americanenglish.state.gov/resources/merriam-webster-learners-dictionary – if English isn't your first language and you want to learn some new vocabulary, look up any unfamiliar words you encounter during your coursework here. This dictionary provides learners of English with a more accessible and easy-to-understand definition of words, along with examples of how to use them in a sentence and how not to use them.

MLA Handbook, 9th edition (the MLA style guide) – for citation and style questions

Revised January 2023

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